Music Lessons

By Sarah Vowell

It was autumn in America. A fine hot Indian summer day. Pretty high school girls sat on bleachers with the sun shining in their pretty hair, watching handsome high school boys play football. And then, it was halftime, which is where I came in . . . I was in marching band.

INTRODUCTION

Today, some of the coolest kids on campus can be found playing a tuba or beating a snare drum on the football field during halftime. Once considered the domain of dorks and geeks, students are now actually eager to be a part of their high school marching band. Unfortunately this was NOT always the case. Do you remember what it meant to be a band member when you were in high school? Music Lessons by Sarah Vowell.

I had a foot-tall, fake fur black hat, with the "shako," strapped under my chin. It not only prevented me from breathing, it rendered me and my comrades in the horn section unstable, so that even though my job was to march around as some kind of

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sick metaphor for teenage military precision, I moved through time and space with the grace and confidence of a puppy walking on a beach ball.

Because of my double shortage of strength and coordination, I barely passed gym. But somehow, I was supposed to lift a baritone horn that measured twice my body weight, blow into it while reading microscopic sheet music, step in a straight line while remembering left foot on beats one and three, right foot on beats two and four, and maneuver myself into cute visual formations.

Halfway through the halftime program, I had to break formation, drop my baritone horn on the field, and sprint to the fifty-yard line. At midfield I picked up my mallets and -- this is what they had been waiting for -- I pounded out a xylophone solo on a little Latin-flavored number called "Tico Tico."

My polo shirt-clad nemesis Andy Heap stood up in the stands screaming, "Whooooo! Whoooo!" This was the same Andy Heap, I might add, who

earlier in the week in music history class had delivered an oral report on Tchaikovsky's lady friend, calling her **Mimi** throughout (even though her name was Nadya). Andy Heap was apparently smart enough to publicly humiliate me during "Tico Tico," he just wasn't smart enough to know that the abbreviation "Mme." stands not for Mimi, but "Madame."

I only had a second to stick out my tongue at Andy when I finished "Tico Tico," because I had to let go of the mallets, rush over to my baritone-again, and I'm back in formation with the low brass for the finale.

I was getting academic credit for this, to wear that uniform to play those songs. I was getting graded. Which begs the question: What exactly was I supposed to be learning? What was marching band supposed to teach me? Because marching isn't a particularly applicable skill in later life. Here then, some lessons -- actually useful ones -- I accidentally learned while pursuing music.

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ACCIDENTAL LESSON #1: MARXISM FOR TENTH GRADERS

Once a week, the best band kids played with the orchestra. I played the bass drum in orchestra, which meant that I never got to play. My participation ratio was something like seventy-five measures of rest per one big bass wallop. This gave me plenty of time to contemplate the class warfare of the situation. Here's what I figured out: Orchestra kids wear tuxedos. Band kids wear tuxedo T-shirts.

The orchestra kids, with their brown woolens and Teutonic last names, had the well-scrubbed, dark blond aura of a Hitler Youth brigade. These were the sons and daughters of humanities professors. They took German. They played soccer. Dumping the fluorescent T-shirts of the band kids into the orchestra each week must have looked like tossing a handful of Skittles into a box of Swiss chocolates.

But nothing brings kids together like hate. The one thing the band kids and the orchestra kids had in

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common was a unified disgust for the chorus kids, who were, to us, merely drama geeks with access to four-part harmony.

ACCIDENTAL LESSON #2: BIOLOGY AS DESTINY

In seventh grade, I started band. I wanted to play the drums. My parents, who lived with me -- as was the custom in Montana -- did not want me to play the drums. So I picked the next loudest instrument instead -- the trumpet. How I loved my trumpet, the feel of it in my hands, its very volume and shine. I especially loved the illicitly named spit valve.

In eighth grade, a teacher told me about this good old trumpet player I might like so I went out and bought one of his records. And every night, for over a year, I went to sleep listening to it, the same songs over and over, trying to figure out why Louis Armstrong was so moving, so funny, so good. I got caught up in this superstar talent of his right around the time I was beginning to suspect that I didn't have it, talent that is.

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There was another problem which I discovered about three years into my trumpet career. I found out that the reason I had shoddy tone and trouble hitting the high notes was because of the shape of my jaw. I felt my life was more or less over. I was outraged that a person's fate could depend on something as arbitrary as the angles of her teeth. And not only that, I had to switch to a brass instrument with a bigger mouthpiece-the baritone horn. The baritone horn. Like, trumpets are played by Miles Davis and baritones are played by ***nobody***.

ACCIDENTAL LESSON #3: HE'S SCHROEDER, I'M CHARLIE BROWN

One of the reasons I knew I wasn't God's gift to music was that I went to school with him -- the living, breathing personification of entertainment -- Jon Wilson. Jon Wilson could play the piano. Like REALLY. PLAY. THE PIANO. He knew all the crowd-pleasing keyboard favorites. Kids would come up to him and request the Charlie Brown theme song or Van Halen's "Jump" so often I'm surprised he didn't roll a

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baby grand with an empty milk carton on tour into the junior high cafeteria and play for tips during lunch.

The thing that bothered me about Jon Wilson, who was actually a pretty nice guy, was that people loved him! Loved him! And our friendly competition heated up when we both got serious about writing music. By fifteen, I was composing orchestral scores which went unperformed for the most part, and justifiably so. They were difficult, unlistenable, and wildly pretentious.

Jon Wilson, on the other hand, wrote sentimental, professional quality love songs a la Lionel Richie and sang them after school in the band room to his fan base of swooning females. Pish-posh, I thought, alone in my two-by-three soundproof practice module that was more than roomy enough to accommodate my admirers. I was convinced that real artists were the kind that nobody understood, much less liked, which was pretty reassuring since nobody liked me. Or my music.

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ACCIDENTAL LESSON #4: WHEN DOVES CRY

From the time I was twelve until I finished high school at eighteen, my poor parents' calendar was blackened by an ambitious roster of concerts and recitals averaging at least one per month. They were always so gushy in their support, it never occurred to me that they might have preferred to avoid junior high school gymnasium performances of the theme from *Rocky*. They acted as though their world revolved around my sister and me, so that's what we believed.

I remember one night, after an eighth-grade band concert, I caught a glimpse of pencil marks on my father's rolled-up program. He told me that he checked off each movement of each piece as it ended. Obviously because he was counting the seconds until he could go home. At the time, I took it badly. I was offended that he had so little regard for the seriousness of our thoughtful, well-rehearsed interpretation of "What Do You Do with a Drunken Sailor." Now, I see those pathetic little checkmarks

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as heart-shaped symbols of his love.

Everyone says that love requires the utmost honesty, but that's not entirely true. Once I knew that my father was suffering for my sake -- really suffering -- I learned that love, especially the parental kind, requires the heartwarming sacrifice that can only accompany fake enthusiasm.

ACCIDENTAL LESSON #5: BIRTH OF THE COOL

So: I was doomed at the trumpet. I was also acceptable at the baritone, shaky on the xylophone, and putrid on the piano. But there was one instrument for which I had an innate knack, an instrument I could play with some semblance of grace . . . the recorder. I taught myself to play it, and by fourteen, I was perhaps the youngest member of the American Recorder Society.

I found out about an amateur ensemble that met once a week in my town. The members of the Bozeman Recorder Ensemble, as we were called, included a retired high school music teacher, two Montana State University math professors, and a

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number of housewives, one of whom had a daughter in my grade. I was the only member under the age of forty and most of them would have been eligible for the senior citizen discount at the music store. I played with them for a couple of years, until my pals Margaret and Leota and I broke off to form our own trio. At school, in all those actual hours of actual classes with actual teachers, music felt more like a job. Playing with Leota and Margaret was the first time -- the only time -- I actually enjoyed playing music.

We played gigs, too, at the library, at street fairs. Imagine playing an Elizabethan ballad on the street with your two friends who happen to be older than your parents. You might look up from your music stand and notice one of your schoolmates staring on in horror. Andy Heap, for instance. But you know what? You don't care. You might even smile at him. And this is the most important lesson of marching band, of public displays of recorder. To withstand embarrassment. Maybe even seek it out. To take nerdiness to its most dizzying extremes, and stand before my peers with my

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head held high. To stick out my tongue at the Andy Heaps of the world, run back to the baritone horn of life, and blow mighty and proud.

CLOSING

[TRUMPET NOISE/FANFARE] Today, I salute all band members who were dedicated to their craft long before being a "Band Geek" was cool.

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